

VIDEO ESSAY

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When the Centre Cannot Hold

*Postmodernism, fragmentation, and the refusal of plot in
Kamal Swaroop's Om-Dar-B-Dar (1988)*

HUM3101: Aesthetics of Film

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Portfolio note

This is a solo video essay made for Aesthetics of Film: a critical reading of Kamal Swaroop's *Om-Dar-B-Dar* (1988) as a work of postmodern cinema. I wrote, narrated, and edited it. This document is the brief. It sets out the argument in written form and the theory it rests on; the video is the primary artefact and is linked below. The written analysis here is mine, tightened from the video's spoken script into critical prose.

When the Centre Cannot Hold: Postmodernism in Om-Dar-B-Dar —
[Watch here](#)

The film, and the problem it poses

Kamal Swaroop's *Om-Dar-B-Dar* (1988) is one of the strangest films Indian cinema has produced — a cult object often called the "Great Indian LSD Trip." Set in a Rajasthani temple town, it follows, loosely, a boy whose only talent is holding his breath, a father who becomes an astrologer, a sister chasing her desires, and a town that descends into chaos over a rumour that frogs contain diamonds. If you ask what happens, the honest answer is that no coherent plot can be reconstructed, and the video essay's opening gambit is to say so plainly: forget the plot. The film does not have one in the conventional sense, and that absence is not a failure. It is the point.

The argument of the video essay is that calling *Om-Dar-B-Dar* "just an acid trip" or "just chaos" misses what it is doing. It is a deliberate work of postmodern cinema, and its fragmentation, irony, and narrative disruption are not accidents of a difficult film but the formal signature of a coherent aesthetic position. The essay reads the film through that lens, and connects each of its strange features to a specific strand of postmodern theory.

The frame: from grand narrative to fragment

The essay sets up its reading with the distinction between modernism and postmodernism. Modernism, emerging in the late nineteenth century, sought grand narratives — structures of reason, science, religion, and social ideology that could be agreed upon and that explained the world as a whole. Postmodernism is the loss of faith in exactly those structures. Its mood is

captured in the lines from W. B. Yeats's "The Second Coming" that give the essay its title: "Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold; / Mere anarchy is loosed upon the world." What Yeats names as catastrophe, postmodernism takes as a starting condition — reality is no longer a single grand story but a scatter of subjective, fragmentary, partial ones.

Om-Dar-B-Dar lives entirely in that scattered condition. There is no narrative arc, no organising whole; there are frames, fragments, and micro-narratives that never resolve into a single account. The essay's central claim is that this is the film enacting postmodernism rather than merely depicting it — building its very form out of the collapse Yeats describes.

The theory the film makes visible

The essay anchors its reading in three thinkers, each illuminating a different feature of the film. Jean-François Lyotard defined the postmodern condition as "incredulity towards metanarratives" — a refusal of the big explanatory stories of religion, science, progress, even family unity (Lyotard, 1984). Om-Dar-B-Dar's refusal of plot is this incredulity made cinematic: by lingering on the small and the absurd — a frog, a held breath — rather than building toward a unifying meaning, Swaroop declines the grand narrative and celebrates the fragment in its place.

Fredric Jameson supplies the second strand. In a culture that has run out of room for genuine originality, Jameson argues, art falls back on imitation; his precise term for this is pastiche, which he distinguishes from parody as "blank parody" — imitation without satirical motive, recombination for its own sake (Jameson, 1991). The essay reads the film's repetitions and loops in this register: the childlike, looping lyrics of a song like "Babli Telephone Se" generate a postmodern texture in which there is no original to be faithful to, so everything can be repeated, mixed, and replayed. The third strand is Michel Foucault's notion of heterotopia — spaces in which multiple incompatible orderings coexist side by side (Foucault, 1986) — which the essay uses to read the film's parallel, simultaneously running storylines that never reconcile into one world.

Form as the argument

The essay's strongest move is to treat the film's formal disruptions as its meaning rather than its obstacles. The most direct of these is the breaking of the fourth wall: throughout Om-Dar-B-Dar,

characters look into the camera and deliver lines in a flat, mundane register, shattering the illusion that we are watching an unmediated reality and insisting instead that what we see is a constructed thing, an artefact, not an absolute. That insistence — this is made, not given — is the postmodern proposition in its purest form, and the essay argues it is the engine of the whole film.

From here the essay positions *Om-Dar-B-Dar* within a wider postmodern cinema: Tarantino's *Pulp Fiction* and *Kill Bill* for their fractured chronology and pastiche, *Blade Runner* for its interrogation of what is real and what is fabricated, and Anurag Kashyap's *Dev.D* as the closer Indian relative. The comparison is not name-dropping; it locates a film easily dismissed as eccentric within a recognised international aesthetic, and argues that Swaroop was working in that mode in 1988, early and largely unrecognised.

The closing turn

The essay ends by returning to its epigraph and inverting it. For Yeats, the centre failing to hold is a vision of dread. The video essay's final proposition is that *Om-Dar-B-Dar* shows the same collapse as something else — that when the centre cannot hold, the resulting anarchy can be beautiful, a playground for the subconscious where the viewer's own associations matter more than any meaning fixed on screen. The film, on this reading, is not asking to be solved. It is asking to be experienced, and its refusal to be pinned to a single set of ideas is precisely its postmodern achievement.

Making the essay in video form rather than as a written paper was a deliberate fit of method to subject. A film that argues meaning is fragmentary and constructed is better answered with image, sound, and edited juxtaposition than with continuous prose — the form of the response mirrors the form of the object. Scripting, narrating, and editing it was the work of translating a theoretical argument into the medium it is about, which is the same translation between idea and audience that runs through the rest of my work.

Sources

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